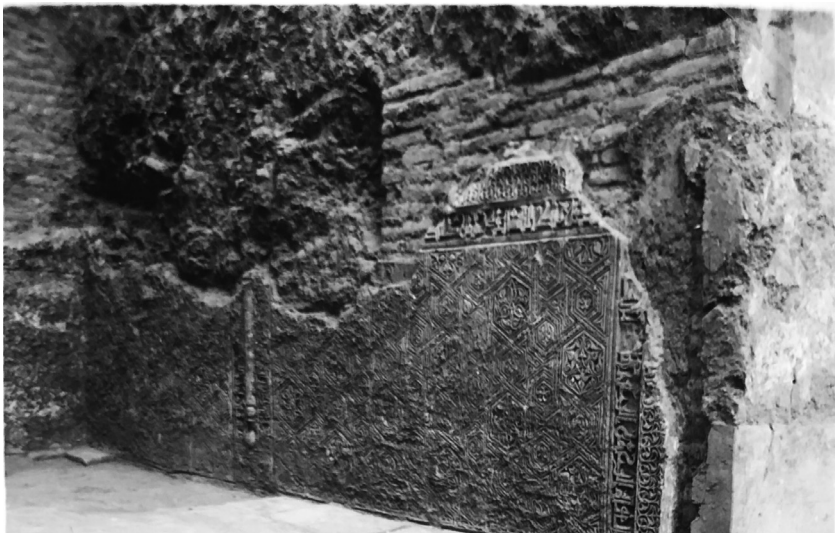


Figure 5.21 *Lashkari Bazar, South Palace, Oratory F, stucco decoration (photograph* c. *1950s). © Courtesy of Musée des Arts Asiatiques-Guimet, Paris.*

south wall, with possibly more verses from the same Sura (Figure 5.21). Oratory F's focal point was of course the west-oriented *mihrab* (Figure 5.22), flanked by several vertical bands of undulating floral arabesques and epigraphy: the band rectangularly framing the *mihrab* contained Q. II:256 (al-Baqara); in the niche's hood was Q. CXII:1–4 (al-Ikhlas) in repetition; and simple doxologies such as *al-mulk li-llah* were repeated in the niche's lower part. The overall decorative program of the Oratory can be aptly characterized as one evincing a *horror vacui*, "the compulsion to cover – almost to swamp – every available space of wall surface with decoration."[46]

We saw in Chapter 4 that several Qur'anic verses in Shansabani-patronized architectural decoration were otherwise rare or undocumented, both in the eastern Persianate regions and in the wider Islamicate lands. To be sure, Q. II:256 – the verse following the practically ubiquitous and revered Ayat al-Kursi (Q. II:255) – also appeared with some frequency in architectural epigraphy, extending from Palermo to Delhi and spanning the tenth through sixteenth centuries CE.[47] However, verses from Q. XLVIII had evidently first appeared in the eastern Islamicate world on the *minar* of Mas'ud III at Ghazna (*c.* AH 503/1110 CE), and within the mosque at Barsiyan in the Isfahan oasis, dated by inscription to AH 528/1134 CE. I subsequently proposed that, in the 1160s–1170s, the Ghazna decorative program had been the underlying inspiration for Shah-i Mashhad's epigraphy, particularly the inscriptional program gracing the complex's imposing south façade. Intriguingly, we shall see in Chapter 6 that the Sura's beginning verses appeared on yet another Shansabani-associated